Survey Methodology

This report is based on findings from seven surveys conducted in the summer and early fall of 2011.

Tablet Owner Phone Surveys

The overall portrait of tablet computer users among the general public is based on aggregated data from five telephone surveys conducted on landlines and cell phones June 30-July 31, 2011 with national samples of adults 18 years of age or older living in the continental United States. Interviews were conducted with a total of 5,014 adults, including 504 who use a tablet computer. A total of 3,150 respondents were interviewed on a landline telephone (including 293 tablet users) and 1,864 were interviewed on a cell phone (including 211 tablet users). The following table shows the field dates and sample sizes for each of the five surveys:

Field dates	Adult sample Size	Tablet user sample size
June 30-July 3, 2011	1,001	92
July 7-10, 2011	1,007	88
July 14-17, 2011	1,006	98
July 21-24, 2011	999	126
July 28-31, 2011	1,001	100
	5,014	**504**

The survey was conducted by interviewers at Princeton Data Source under the direction of Princeton Survey Research Associates International. A combination of landline and cell phone random digit dial samples were used; both samples were provided by Survey Sampling International. Interviews were conducted in English. Respondents in the landline sample were selected by randomly asking for the youngest adult male or female who is now at home. Interviews in the cell sample were conducted with the person who answered the phone, if that person was an adult 18 years of age or older.

The combined landline and cell phone sample are weighted using an iterative technique that matches gender, age, education, race, Hispanic origin, region, and population density to parameters from the March 2010 Census Bureau's Current Population Survey. The sample also is weighted to match current patterns of telephone status, based on extrapolations from the 2010 National Health Interview Survey. The weighting procedure also accounts for the fact that respondents with both landline and cell phones have a greater probability of being included in the combined sample and adjusts for household size within the landline sample. Sampling errors and statistical tests of significance take into account the effect of weighting.

The error attributable to sampling that would be expected at the 95% level of confidence is plus or minus 2.0 percentage points for the total sample of 5,014 adults and 5.5 percentage points for the sample of 504 tablet users. In addition to sampling error, one should bear in mind that question wording and practical difficulties in conducting surveys can introduce error or bias into the findings of opinion polls.

Pew Research Tablet User Panel

Two additional surveys were conducted with adults in the Pew Research tablet user panel, created specifically for this study. This panel was developed by recontacting people previously identified as having a tablet computer in a large-scale survey effort that interviewed more than 40,000 adults from March to July 2011. Approximately 55% of the U.S. adult population lived in areas included in this survey; the sampling design for this survey was targeting a particular subgroup so it excluded areas of the U.S. with very few members of this subgroup.

To evaluate whether tablet users in this panel were similar to those reached in the general public survey, we compared the demographic characteristics of tablet users across both surveys and measures of how often people use their tablets overall and for specific activities. In addition, we compared a basic measure of news consumption and whether the tablet has changed how much time people are spending with the news across the two groups. See Appendix for these comparisons.

Tablet News Phone Survey

The first survey with the panel was conducted by telephone on landlines and cell phones July 15-30, 2011. Interviews were conducted with 1,159 members of the panel (635 by landline and 524 by cell phone), including 894 who get news on their tablet at least weekly. The survey was conducted by interviewers at Princeton Data Source under the direction of Princeton Survey Research Associates International. Interviews were conducted in English. Interviewers asked to speak with the person (identified by gender and age) who previously took part in a short telephone survey. After that person came to the phone, additional questions confirmed that they have a tablet computer (not another type of device) and that they themselves actually use the tablet computer.

The sample was weighted using an iterative technique that matched age, education, race and region to parameters based on tablet users identified in the general public survey. Sampling errors and statistical tests of significance take into account the effect of weighting. See the Appendix for a comparison of the parameters for tablet users from the general public survey and the unweighted and weighted demographics of tablet users from the Pew Research panel phone survey.

The following table shows the sample sizes and the error attributable to sampling that would be expected at the 95% level of confidence for different groups in the survey:

Group	Sample Size	Plus or minus …
All tablet users	1,159	3.5 percentage points
Tablet news users	894	4.0 percentage points
Get news on tablet…		
Mostly through browser	347	6.5 percentage points
Mostly through apps	208	8.5 percentage points
Both equally	275	7.5 percentage points

In addition to sampling error, one should bear in mind that question wording and practical difficulties in conducting surveys can introduce error or bias into the findings of opinion polls.

The response rate for the phone survey of the Pew Research tablet user panel was 22% in the landline sample and 28% in the cell sample. The response rate for the original screener survey, from which the sample for the tablet user panel was drawn, was 22% in the landline random digit dial (RDD) sample and 20% in the cell RDD sample.

Tablet News Web Survey

The second survey of the Pew Research tablet user panel was conducted online September 6-19, 2011 among a select group of respondents who get news on their tablet at least weekly and indicated they would be willing to be re-contacted by email for another survey. A total of 300 completed the follow-up web interview. This survey probed specifically on tablet news consumption in the past 7 days. The web survey was conducted in English by Princeton Survey Research Associates International. The initial question in the survey confirmed that the respondent had and still used their tablet computer.

The error attributable to sampling that would be expected at the 95% level of confidence is plus or minus 6.0 percentage points for the total sample of 300 tablet news users (who get news on their tablet at least weekly). In addition to sampling error, one should bear in mind that question wording and practical difficulties in conducting surveys can introduce error or bias into the findings of opinion polls.

All of those who agreed to be re-contacted and for whom we had a mailing address were sent an advance letter on August 15, 2011 to inform them they would receive an email invitation in the coming weeks and to give them $5 as a token of appreciation for completing the phone survey. The survey invitation was sent by email on August 30th and explained the purpose of the study, encouraged participation, provided the survey link and unique identification number and informed respondents they would receive $25 for completing the survey. Two additional email reminders were sent to all those who had not yet completed the survey on September 13th and September 16th. All respondents who completed the survey and provided a mailing address were sent $25 for their participation.

The response rate for the web survey, which was sent to a subsample of respondents from the initial phone survey with the Pew Research tablet user panel, was 46%.

APPENDIX

Demographic Comparison of Tablet Users From General Public Survey and Pew Research Panel

	Tablet users from general public survey	Tablet users from Pew Research panel	
		Unweighted	Weighted
Gender	%	%	%
Men	52	53	54
Women	48	47	46
Age			
18-24	13	8	12
25-34	21	16	21
35-44	25	22	25
45-54	20	22	20
55-64	15	20	15
65+	7	13	7
Education			
College graduate+	51	70	23
Some college	23	21	24
High school or less	26	9	53
Race			
White	74	85	77
Black	13	9	13
Other	12	6	11
Region			
Northeast	18	19	19
Midwest	18	20	18
South	38	31	37
West	26	31	26

Tablet Usage Comparison of Tablet Users From General Public Survey and Pew Research Panel

	Tablet users from general public survey	Tablet users from Pew Research panel
How often use tablet?	%	%
Several times a day	59	61
About once a day	18	16
A few times a week	13	14
About once a week	4	4
Less often	6	5
Mean # of minutes spent on tablet yesterday	108	95
Use tablet at least daily to…		
Browse or search the web	66	67
Send or receive email	56	54
Get news, including everything from the latest headlines to in-depth articles and commentary	53	52
Use social networking sites, like Facebook, Twitter or LinkedIn	41	39
Play games	23	30
Create and edit documents	22	17
Read books	19	12
Watch movies or video	16	12
Read magazines	10	7
How often do you like to follow the news?		
All or most of the time	62	68
Some of the time	20	18
Only now and then	9	9
Hardly ever	9	5
Never/Don't know (Vol.)	1	*
Among tablet news users: Do you spend ___ getting news now that you have a tablet		
More time	23	30
Less time	5	4
Same amount of time	71	65
Don't know (Vol.)	1	*